





Think what you may of Zoya Akhtar's *The Archies*, which released on December 7 on Netflix, most agree that her Riverdale of 1964 would be one of India's top places to visit. Only if it was real. To bring alive this world, Akhtar turned to two of her frequent collaborators—production designer Suzanne Caplan Merwanji and costume designer Poornamrita Singh. Her brief to them was simple: the film is based on the comics but it has to have "a storybook" look to it. "We definitely wanted a magical feel to it," says Akhtar. "When you step into Riverdale, it's like nothing you've ever known."

Dressed to the Nines

Poornamrita Singh was thrilled to work on the film because the 1960s are her favourite decade, with a lot of her own wardrobe drawn from that time period. For Singh, the decade is best known for its "timeless" and "flattering" fashion, which is why clothes from it—short shirts, A-line and shift dresses—are in vogue even today. The colour palette of *The Archies*, says Singh, "was all muted" and isn't easily accessible in India today.

To nail the sartorial aesthetic, Singh visited London, where vintage stores and flea markets became her hunting grounds for not just clothes but also accessories (hats, watches) and jewellery (brooches). "I picked up a lot of cute, eclectic stuff not knowing who I would put it on. I just knew it fits in the *Archies* world," says Singh, who worked with Akhtar on *Gully Boy* and *Made in Heaven*. "All the vintage stores had really tiny clothes, including shoes. I wondered who will fit into them." Luckily, the cast of 20-somethings was petite. "They seamlessly fit into those things," recalls Singh.

Readymade buys though were only part of the wardrobe; most clothes had to be stitched. From embroideries to crochet tops, the tailors had their hands full. Given the hill-station setting, woollens were needed too. Singh bought sweaters from an NGO in Dehradun, apart from customising them.

Her inspiration included not just the comics (polo necks for Jughead, round glasses for Dilton), but also photos of the Anglo-Indian community, illustrations and paintings of American artist Norman Rockwell as well as storybook covers published in the 1950s and '60s. "I had to amalgamate the era, the community, the characters from the comic books and the individual personalities," says Singh.

The outfits were a hit among both cast and crew, with members "claiming things" to take home after the shoot. For Singh, it was validation for what she set out to do—to have clothes that are true to the period



CINEMA

Labour of Love

*From humble beginnings two decades ago, the **Chennai International Film Festival** has grown thanks to the efforts of festival director E. Thangaraj*

E. Thangaraj is a simple man with a big heart for cinema. A former Reserve Bank of India employee, his has been the name at the forefront of the Chennai International Film Festival ever since its humble beginnings in 2003. As General Secretary of the Indo Cine Appreciation Foundation (ICAF), a registered nonprofit organisation working for the promotion of cinema, he has helped the festival grow over the last 20 years. The 21st edition (December 14-21, 2023) is here and as festival director, there is no one more involved in day-to-day operations as well as in the work that happens in the months preceding it.

FILM CITY stills from *Perfect Days* and (left) *Anatomy of a Fall*, and (inset), E. Thangaraj

